

THE TEN BIG MI

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

The nub of a successful anti-terrorist operation lies in the initial hours of an attack when a delay by the first responders could mean the difference between success and catastrophic failure. In Mumbai on 26/11, most of the mistakes, it now transpires, took place in the initial hours. The first responders were the Mumbai city police. Unable to distinguish a fidayeen attack from an underworld shootout, hobbled by a lack of even basic firearms, inadequate anti-terror forces and a clueless senior leadership, the men in khaki lost the plot. The National Security Guard (NSG) commandos arrived in the city nearly seven hours after they had been mobilised at their base in Manesar on the outskirts of Delhi. They had to play a deadly game of cat and mouse against 10 hardened, motivated and well-trained terrorists with enough ammunition to last days. During the three-day siege, nearly 900 hotel rooms could not be entirely cleared of guests. When the dust had settled on one of India's longest anti-terrorist operations, the mistakes were glaring.

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09.30 p.m.

Inability to Distinguish Between Terror Attack and Gang War

The confusion surrounding the attack gave enough time for the terrorists to wreak havoc

At 9.38 on Wednesday night, two Lashkar gunmen Abdul Rehman and Abu Umer tossed in grenades and sprayed bullets from their assault rifles at the hapless diners in Leopold Cafe, starting a 60-hour siege of Mumbai. For the next half-hour, the five fidayeen buddy pairs ran through South Mumbai, wreaking havoc with guns and grenades. In the span of half an hour, calls of attacks at multiple locations kept pouring into the police control room. The initial assessment: it was an underworld attack. Two IEDs, which the terrorists planted in taxis after boarding them soon after alighting from the rubber dinghy at Colaba, went off at separate places in Vile Parle and Crawford Market an hour later. This further added to the



TV GRAB OF KASAB

confusion. It took the police nearly three hours to decide that it was a terror attack. These precious hours allowed the terrorists to achieve complete surprise and gain the dominant ground at the Oberoi and Taj Mahal hotels, Nariman House, and take hostages.

10.00 p.m.

Mumbai Police Outgunned

The Mumbai Police's obsolete weaponry was no match for the terrorists' automatic weapons

The Lashkar gunmen came armed with AK-47s, grenades and IEDs. Ranged against them was the Mumbai Police constabulary who made a feeble attempt to respond with vintage weaponry. The results were heartbreaking, and nowhere was this more evident than the platforms of the CST station where Ajmal Amir Kasab and Abu Ismail strolled about firing at passengers. After the gunfire started, many railway police personnel ran across to the railway police storeroom a few blocks away to fetch their weapons. One of

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IN THE FIRST THREE HOURS, 16 MUMBAI POLICEMEN, INCLUDING EIGHT OFFICERS, LAY DEAD.